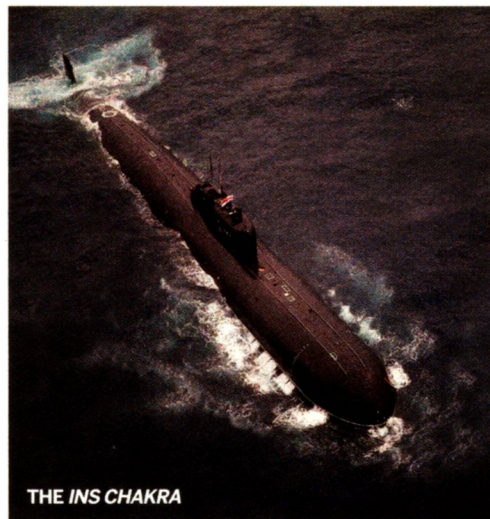


DELHI | Out of the Dock

After a seemingly endless wait, the flood-gates in the drydock where India's first nuclear powered submarine is being built, will finally be opened to the sea. One of the dates being considered for the launch of what is euphemistically called the 'Advanced Technology Vessel (ATV)' at Visakhapatnam's Naval Dockyard is July 26. The date marks Vijay Diwas, the 10th anniversary of the eviction of Pakistani intruders from the Kargil heights. The launch of the 6,000-tonne submarine—for long one of India's most closely guarded defence secrets—is part of a joint navy and DRDO project to provide a secure second-strike capability or the ability to launch nuclear weapons from underwater without detection. The sub (a modified design of Russia's Charlie class nuclear powered submarine which India leased and used as the *INS Chakra* for three years) will make India the sixth country in the world to operate an N-sub. The launch is only the first step in a two-year process where the sub-



THE INS CHAKRA

marine will undergo harbour trials of its nuclear reactor and systems before the vital sea trials. Two more hulls are ready for fabrication at the Shipbuilding Centre, a drydock in the Naval Dockyard.

by Sandeep Unnithan

DELHI | Free Flying

The Centre has given babus a Diwali bonus well in advance. A new circular states, "Government servants shall be allowed to avail facility of the free companion tickets offered by airlines for international travel". The Finance Ministry had earlier stated that "packages such as free companion should be so negotiated by ministries so that the Government benefits". Bureaucracy lobbied hard and it looks like they've succeeded. Recently, government officers of the rank of director and above have flown air miles equal to 74 return trips to the moon.

by Shyamal Yadav

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